

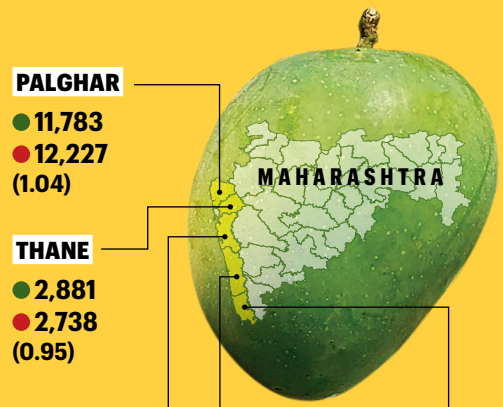
cultivation and tourism are what transformed Konkan's money-order economy, where the men worked in blue-collar jobs in and around Mumbai and sent money home. Alphonso is estimated to be grown on 1.26 lakh hectares in five districts of Maharashtra—Sindhudurg, Ratnagiri, Raigad, Thane and Palghar. Of this, 14,920 ha. is in Devgad, producing around 50,000 tonnes of Alphonso every year. The harvesting takes place in three stages—February-end to mid-March, mid-March to mid-April and mid-April to May.

The Devgad cultivators are now clamouring for a separate GI registry. Says Ajit Gogate, former MLA and chairman of the Devgad Taluka Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sanstha Maryadit, "For years, mangoes from other parts have been sold as Devgad mangoes, but our mangoes have a distinct quality and taste." The hallmark Alphonso taste is a product of its geography, says journalist Sopan Joshi in his book *Mangifera Indica*, derived from the Konkan's rich iron-laden laterite soil.

Counterfeit Hapus are affecting the Devgad mango brand, says Omkar Sapre, board member and advisor to the Devgad mango growers association, and cultivators are suffering. "The younger generation is forced to migrate elsewhere and some local men are unable to get brides," he claims. The Devgad Taluka

NO AAM MANGO

The five Maharashtra districts where the original Alphonso is cultivated



PALGHAR
● 11,783
● 12,227
(1.04)

THANE
● 2,881
● 2,738
(0.95)

RAIGAD
● 15,547
● 29,450
(1.89)

RATNAGIRI
● 67,796
● 1,23,068
(3)

SINDHUDURG
● 33,920
● 42,400
(1.25)

● Area in hectare ● Production in tonnes
Average production per hectare in tonnes in ( )

A POTTED HISTORY

- **The Alphonso is said to have got its name from the Portuguese general Afonso de Albuquerque. Grafted by Jesuit missionaries in the 16th century, it soon travelled across the Konkan**
- **This mango variety has a thin skin, distinctive aroma, a small nose, and thick, fibreless pulp. Its unique taste comes from the area's mineral-rich red laterite soil**
- **Besides the Alphonso, 14 other varieties have been given the GI tag–Marathwada Kesar (Maharashtra), Mankurad (Goa), Banaganapalle (Telangana and Andhra Pradesh), Malda Laxman Bhog, Khirsapati and Fazli (West Bengal), Kuttiattoor (Kerala), Gir Kesar (Gujarat), Rewa Sunderja (MP), Kari Ishad and Appemidi (Karnataka), Banaras Langda, Rataul and Malihabadi Dussehri (UP)**